MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 2 — Unit 3: Poetry - Pope, Burns and Blake

MILTON TO THE PRE-ROMANTICS • M21EG03DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Pope, Burns, and Blake use very different poetic forms to test reputation, affection, innocence, and the unsettling power of creation.

Start with a picture

A lock of hair becomes an epic prize; a song promises love beyond distance; two creatures prompt different questions about their maker. The poems make familiar objects do intellectual work.

1. Pope: The Rape of the Lock

A fashionable conflict over the cutting of Belinda’s hair becomes a five-canto mock epic. The Baron’s desire, Ariel and the sylphs, the game of ombre, the scissors, the Cave of Spleen, and the final transformation enlarge the event through epic conventions.

The historical use of rape in the title concerns forcible seizure. That does not make bodily autonomy or Belinda’s injury meaningless. A good reading can examine the inflated social value of reputation while acknowledging unequal gendered stakes.

Epic machinery includes supernatural agents and large ceremonial comparisons. Toilet preparations can resemble arming for battle; a social game can resemble warfare. Heroic couplets give the wit a carefully patterned force.

Clarissa’s speech offers an argument about conduct, but should be analysed within the poem rather than automatically accepted as an unqualified authorial statement.

2. Burns: A Red, Red Rose

The lyric draws on song and Scots language. Four quatrains move from comparisons with a fresh rose and harmonious music towards declarations of endurance, farewell, and promised return.

The images of seas drying and rocks melting are **hyperbole**, deliberate exaggeration expressing emotional scale. The poem does not supply a definite practical reason for the separation, so do not invent one.

Freshness and lasting commitment coexist in the argument. The musical form makes a personal declaration repeatable through song.

3. Blake: The Lamb

A childlike speaker asks about the lamb's maker and gives an answer through Christian associations of the lamb, the child, and gentleness. Repetition and apparently simple questions create a mode of trust.

The simplicity is crafted, not evidence that the poem has no ideas or formal organisation.

4. Blake: The Tyger

Repeated questions examine the source of a creature's fierce beauty. Fire, bodily making, and forge imagery combine wonder with fear. The poem does not provide the same settled answer as The Lamb.

The question about whether the same maker created both creatures leaves the relation between gentleness and power unresolved. The tiger should not be reduced to a label meaning evil.

5. Comparing techniques

Pope's mock-epic inflation, Burns's song and hyperbole, and Blake's symbolic questioning direct the reader differently. Explain how the poem moves, not only what its central object represents.

Quick check

1. Does mock epic make every injury trivial? **Not necessarily.**
2. Does Burns explain exactly why the lover leaves? **No.**
3. Does The Tyger end with the same certainty as The Lamb? **No.**

Build an exam answer

1. Identify each work and its form.
2. Explain mock-epic inflation with its ethical tensions.
3. Analyse song and hyperbole in Burns.
4. Compare Blake's answers and questions.
5. Connect imagery with the reader's confidence or doubt.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not confuse A Red, Red Rose with Ae Fond Kiss merely because the source bibliography mixes references; do not equate the Tyger simply with evil.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

How do the selected poems use form and imagery to challenge or sustain confidence?

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

The poems' subjects become meaningful through different structures of address and comparison. Pope's mock epic challenges the scale of a fashionable society's values by applying grand conventions to a personal social conflict. Yet the mock-heroic mismatch does not eliminate the real questions of consent, reputation, and gender through which that conflict operates.

Burns uses a song form to make an intimate promise durable and memorable. The movement from fresh beauty to extreme declarations of endurance creates a tension between immediate feeling and continuing commitment. Hyperbole expresses emotional conviction rather than a claim that the speaker can literally outlive the end of the seas.

Blake's paired lyrics examine confidence more directly. The Lamb shapes a trusting answer through repetition and Christian association, while The Tyger returns to questions that remain unresolved. Its forge and fire images make creation seem both marvellous and disturbing. Reading the poems together prevents an easy division into a good creature and an evil one.

A strong comparison identifies those different formal effects. Satirical enlargement, musical repetition, and unanswered interrogation are not interchangeable decorations. They determine how a poem invites readers to judge, believe, or remain uncertain.

Use the discussion well

Answer the exact question, not every possible topic. Make one clear point per paragraph, support it with a textual detail or a relevant classroom example, and explain its significance. Check exact quotations against the assigned text. The discussion is paraphrase and guidance, not a quotation or a guaranteed exam answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

The following numbered prompts are retained from the unit for revision. Obvious source errors are discussed in the coverage review; a prompt's assumptions should not be accepted automatically. These are not predictions or complete written assignments.

1. Consider the poem The Rape of The Lock as a mock-epic.
2. How does the work critique the social life of the upper class of the time ?
3. Examine the metaphorical and symbolic implications of cutting Belinda's hair?
4. Discuss the satirical elements in the works of Alexander Pope
5. Who is the rich heroine in the poem?
6. Who are the invisible army who help Belinda with her face, hair, and outfit?
7. What is the total length of Robert Burns' piece on endless love, 'A Red, Red Rose?
8. Which dialect of English is used in 'A Red, Red Rose?

9. What instructions does the speaker give his lover?
10. Why does the speaker have to part from his lover?
11. William Blake’s symbolism in “The Tyger”.
12. How does Blake criticise man’s actions by comparing them to the image of a Tyger?
13. How is childhood depicted in ‘The Lamb’?
14. “Little Lamb who made thee” – Comment.